

2.2 Unseen close reading

Paper 2 Prose and Unseen · 2026 examination · Concept guide and original exam-style practice

Understand the concept

Read the whole unseen text first for situation, voice and any turn before annotating local details. Build an interpretation from patterns of diction, rhythm, perspective and structure. Refer to the beginning and ending; alternative readings must remain anchored in textual evidence, without biography or invented historical context.

Worked example: follow the reasoning

A repeated image of a bridge can shift from connection to distance when a final sentence reveals it is closed; show the change in sequence rather than treating all occurrences as identical.

Original practice stimulus

Each morning she set two cups on the table. At first she filled both, setting the second within reach of the empty chair. Later she stopped filling it but kept its handle turned toward the chair, as if the arrangement mattered more than the tea. Visitors asked about the cup, and she answered that the cupboard was crowded. By winter the second cup held only the kitchen light. On the first warm morning of spring, she carried it to the sink and washed it carefully. She returned it to the table before opening the window. The movement was ordinary; nothing in the room looked settled when she had finished.

Extended response

Compose your response in the space provided and support your interpretation with evidence.

1 Original extract: "Each morning she set two cups on the table. By winter the second [25]
cup held only the kitchen light." Comment on ways time and image convey change.

Check: relevant evidence · coherent argument · accurate and deliberate language

Answers and explanation

Question 1 [25 marks]

A strong answer connects “each morning” to ritual and “by winter” to elapsed time; the absent companion is suggested, not confirmed. The second cup becomes a vessel for light rather than tea, allowing grief, separation or change as supported interpretations.

Self-assessment

Compare each credited step with your own answer. Fix the first reasoning or calculation error; then retry without looking at the solution.

Syllabus: Literature in English 9695, 2024–2026.

<https://www.cambridgeinternational.org/Images/636097-2024-2026-syllabus.pdf>

Original FagusED teaching material. Question layout and mark presentation informed by the May/June 2026 papers supplied by the user. The practice question is newly written and is not a Cambridge past-paper question.